



GREAT ESCAPE: Dalai Lama (centre) with bodyguards after fleeing Lhasa

During this period, General B.M. Kaul, the then chief of general staff, told the US ambassador John Galbraith "that the Chinese were not operating from strength; the Indian Army viewed the Chinese as set in a 'mood' for weakness and the Indian policy was to take maximum advantage of this mood by establishing maximum posts ... Indian army is not in a mood to be pushed around."

But the military assessment proved to be inaccurate and according to the CIA's account of the Indian Cabinet meeting held on August 1, 1962 the then defence minister V.K. Krishna Menon said, "Indian military position in Ladakh were untenable, Indian forward posts would be wiped out and the Chinese could, if they desired, push the Indians far beyond their 1960 claim."

The papers also comment on the role of the Soviet Union, which was a strong friend of India and its leader Nikita Khrushchev. Even though the then Soviet Union did not cast its lot with China despite the Chinese attempts to get Moscow on board citing the Communist card, Indian establishment was unimpressed by the Russian role. "Indian Foreign Secretary S. Dutt told an US official that Khrushchev was

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"For Indian Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru, who was reluctant to further strain Sino-Indian relations, asylum and sympathy constituted the practical limit of support for the Dalai Lama. He told the Tibetan leader to limit his activities in India to religious affairs and Indian officials were probably reflecting Nehru's real anxiety when they stated privately that the Government would not be sorry to see the Dalai Lama leave the country. "

no help with the Chinese at all."

The CIA papers are surprisingly blank on the US approach and role it played during this crucial period. Despite the obvious drawbacks, some analysts believe that the papers do have a relevance in the contemporary perspective. "The Sino-India war of 1962 and the Chinese betrayal of Nehru points to one thing that the Chinese can go to any length for territorial gains from their neighbours; they did that then in 1962, and even now they claim Arunachal Pradesh as their own territory despite an agreement that settled populations will not be disturbed," says former Indian for-

eign secretary, S.K. Singh, who is now the Governor of Arunachal Pradesh. "These papers provide yet another reminder of why we can't trust the Chinese. They can go back on their word. On the border issue, we need to be careful while negotiating with them," cautions strategic analyst Brahma Chellaney. However, others like Vinod Khanna, a former Indian ambassador and director, Institute of Chinese Studies, says: "There is nothing that is startlingly new in these papers. India and China are two mature powers and are not going to be rattled by CIA writings of 40 years ago." Thereby hangs a tale. ■